

Anthropology

- **Course Information:**
 - ✓ **Course Name: Social Anthropology**
 - ✓ **Course Code: Anth1002**
 - ✓ **Credit Hours: 2 Cr. Hrs.**

Course Description:

- The course is expected to acquaint/familiarize, inform/ you with **essential concept of anthropology** covering a wide array of questions revolving around our very existence.
- It covers issues such as:
 - ✓ What makes human beings similar to each other?
 - ✓ How do we differ one another?
 - ✓ What do anthropologist mean when they talk about diversity, multiculturalism, marginalization, inclusion and exclusion?
 - ✓ The course will enable learners grasp the different ways of being human **by dealing with themes such as:**
 - culture, kinship(relationship, association) ,
 - marriage,
 - cultural relativism, ethnocentrism,
 - humanity, human origins, cosmologies (the study of the origin and structure of universe),
 - race, ethnicity, ethnic relations, ethnic boundaries,
 - marginalization, minorities,
 - local systems of governance, legal pluralism,
 - indigenous knowledge systems, and indigenous practices and development.

Course Objectives:

Up on the successful completion of the course, students will be able to:

- Develop an **understanding of the nature of anthropology** and its broader scope in making sense of humanity in a global perspective;
- Understand the **cultural and biological diversity of humanity** and unity in diversity across the world and in Ethiopia;
- Analyze the **problems of ethnocentrism against the backdrop of cultural relativism**;
- Realize the **socially constructed nature of identities & social categories such as gender, ethnicity, race and sexuality**;
- Explore **the various peoples and cultures of Ethiopia**;

- Understand the social, cultural, political, religious & economic life of different ethno-linguistic & cultural groups of Ethiopia;
- Understand different forms marginalization and develop skills inclusiveness;
- Appreciate the customary systems of governance and conflict resolution institutions of the various peoples of Ethiopia;
- Know about values, norms and cultural practices that maintain society together;
- Recognize the culture area of peoples of Ethiopia and the forms of interaction developed over time among themselves; and
- Develop broader views and skills to deal with people from a wide variety of socio-economic and cultural backgrounds.

Unit One: Introducing Anthropology and its Subject Matter

Chapter Introduction:

- This unit deals with anthropology's essence.
- In this unit, you will be introduced to define concepts crucial for grasping the meaning of anthropology.
- It also explains anthropology's historical development, scope, subject matter, subfields, unique features and contributions.
- In due course, students are required to assume active role in class activities and discussions; sharing of experiences, undertake different debates and arguments and take-home assignments.

1. Definition of Anthropology

- To begin with the **etymology** of the term, the term anthropology is a compound of two Greek words, '**anthropos**' and '**logos**', which can be translated as '**human being/mankind**' and '**reason/study/science**', respectively.
- So, anthropology means '**reason about humans**' or '**the study or science of humankind or humanity**'.
- Moreover, man has two important characteristics: **biological and cultural**: It is very important to understand that the biological and the cultural **characteristics are inseparable elements**.
- **Culture influences human physical structures and the vise-versa.**

- Yet this literal definition **is not particularly illuminating**; because a number of other academic disciplines—including sociology, biology, psychology, political science, economics, and history—also study human beings.
- **What is it that distinguishes anthropology from all of these other disciplines?**
- Anthropology is the study of people—**their origins, their development, and contemporary variations, wherever and whenever they have been found.**
- **It is a broad scientific discipline dedicated to the comparative study of humans as a group, from its first appearance on earth to its present stage of development.**
- Of all the disciplines that study humans, anthropology **is by far the broadest in scope.**

❑ In more specific terms, anthropology is a science which:

- Investigates the strategies for living that are learned and shared by people as members of human social groups;
- Examines the characteristics that human beings share as members of one species (homo sapiens) and the diverse ways that people live in different environments;
- Analyses the products of social groups -material objects (material cultures) and non-material creations (religion/beliefs, social values, institutions, practices, etc).
- **Anthropology** is an intellectually challenging, theoretically ambitious subject, which tries to achieve an understanding of culture, society and humanity through detailed studies of community life, supplemented by comparison.
- At the deepest level, it raises philosophical questions, which it tries to respond to by exploring human lives under different conditions.

- It seeks to explain how and why people are both similar and different through examination of our biological and cultural past and comparative study of contemporary human societies.
- **Its ultimate goal is to develop an integrated picture of humankind**—a goal that encompasses an almost infinite number of questions about all aspects of our existence.
- We ask, for example, what makes us human? Why do some groups of people tend to be tall and lanky, while others tend to be short and stocky? Why do some groups of people practice agriculture, while others hunt for a living?

- As a matter of simplicity and brevity, anthropology primarily offers **two kinds of insight:**
 1. **First**, *the discipline produces knowledge about the actual biological and cultural variations in the world;*
 2. **Second**, *anthropology offers methods and theoretical perspectives enabling the practitioner to explore, compare, understand and solve these varied expressions of the human condition.*

2. The Historical Development of Anthropology

- Like the other social sciences, anthropology is a fairly recent discipline.
- It was given its present shape during the twentieth century, but it has important forerunners in the historiography, geography, travel writing, philosophy and jurisprudence (the science or philosophy of law) of earlier times.
- If we restrict ourselves to anthropology as a scientific discipline, some would trace its roots back to the European Enlightenment, during the eighteenth century;
- Others would claim that anthropology did not arise as a science until the 1850s,
- Yet others would argue that anthropological research in its present-day sense only commenced after the First World War. Nor can we avoid such ambiguities.

- Anthropology, considered as the science of humanity, originated in the region we commonly but inaccurately call 'the West', notably in three or four 'Western' countries: France, Great Britain, the USA and, until the Second World War, Germany (Erikson, 2001).
- The present academic anthropology has its roots in the works and ideas of the great ancient and Medieval Greek, Roman, and Hebrew philosophers and social thinkers. These people were interested in the nature, origin and destiny/intention/ of man, and the morality and ethics of human relationships.
- While the roots of anthropology can be generally traced through the history of western culture as far back as ancient Greek social philosophical thinking, the discipline did not emerge as distinct field of study until the mid-nineteenth century.
- Generally speaking, anthropology as an academic discipline was born during the 19th century, out of the intellectual atmosphere of **Enlightenment**, which is the eighteenth century social philosophical movement.
- By the late 1870s, anthropology was beginning to emerge as a profession. A major impetus for its growth was the expansion of western colonial powers and their consequent desire to better understand the peoples living under colonial domination.

- During its formative years, anthropology became a profession primarily in museums. In this regard, in the 1870s and 1880s many museums devoted to the study of humankind were found in Europe, North America and South America.
- Early anthropologists mainly studied small communities in technologically simple societies. Such societies are often called by various names, such as, “traditional”, “non-industrialized and/or simple societies”.
- Anthropologists of the early 1900s emphasized **the study of social and cultural differences among human groups**. Here, many of the indigenous peoples of non-western world and their social and cultural features were studied in detail and documented. This approach is called **ethnography**.

- By the mid-1900, however, anthropologists attempted to discover universal human patterns and the common bio-psychological traits that bind all human beings. This approach is called **ethnology**. Ethnology aims at the comparative understanding and analysis of different ethnic groups across time and space.
- In Ethiopia, professional anthropologists have been studying culture and society on a more intensive level only since the late 1950s. Almost inevitably, the initial emphasis was on ethnography, the description of specific customs, cultures and ways of life.

Scope and subject matter of Anthropology

- The breadth and depth of anthropology is immense/vast.
- There no time and space left as far as man exists.
- It is so wide as an ocean.
- In other words, the temporal dimension covers the past, the present and even the future.
- In terms of the spatial dimension, anthropology studies from Arctic to Desert, from Mega polis to hunting gathering areas.
- The discipline covers all aspects of human ways of life experiences and existence, as humans live in a social group.
- It touches all aspect of human conditions as far as there is a relation between human beings and natural environment and man and man.
- Anthropology studies humanity with its all aspects of existence, and in its all means of differences (diversity) and similarities (commonality).
- Where every human, there is always anthropology.

- The areas covered by anthropology is diverse and enormous.
- Anthropologists strive for an understanding of the biological and cultural origins and evolutionary development of the species.
- They are concerned with all humans, both past and present, as well as their behavior patterns, thought systems, and material possessions.
- In short, anthropology aims to describe, in the broadest sense, what it means to be human (Peacock, 1986).

Sub-fields of Anthropology

- There is no time, space and characteristics left to study human beings. It is so wide as an ocean.
- Accordingly, it is required to divide and understand in-depth. Accordingly, anthropology has often categorized into **four major sub fields**:
 - ✓ Physical/Biological Anthropology,
 - ✓ Archeology,
 - ✓ Linguistic Anthropology and
 - ✓ Socio-Cultural Anthropology.

1. Physical/Biological Anthropology

- Is the branch of anthropology most closely **related to the natural sciences, particularly biology**; that is why it is often called biological anthropology.
- Physical anthropologists study **how culture and environment have influenced these two areas of biological evolution and contemporary variations.**
- Human biology affects or even explains some aspects of behavior, society, and culture like marriage patterns, sexual division of labor, gender ideology etc.
- The features of **culture in turn have biological effects like the standards of attractiveness, food preferences, and human sexuality.**
- Biological variations such as morphology/structure, color, and size are reflections of changes in living organism. Since change occurs in the universe, it also applies in human beings.

- Human biological variations are the result of the cumulative processes of invisible changes occurring in every fraction of second in human life.
- These changes have been accumulated and passed through genes. Genes are characteristics that carry biological traits of an organism, including human beings.
- The major sources of biological variations are **derived from the interrelated effects of natural selection, geographical isolation, genetic mutations/changes.**
- Physical anthropology is essentially concerned with two broad areas of investigation: ***human evolution*** and **genetics**.
- **Human evolution** is the study of **the gradual processes of simple forms into more differentiated structures** in hominid. It is interested in reconstructing the evolutionary record of the human species using fossils/bones.

- Human evolution is further divided into **two** specialties: ***Paleoanthropology*** and ***Primatology***.
- **Paleoanthropology** (*paleo* meaning “old”) is the study of human biological evolution **through the analysis of fossil remains from prehistoric times** to determine the missing link that connect modern human with its biological ancestors.
- **Primatology** **studies about primates or recent human ancestors** to explain human evolution. Primatologists study the anatomy/ structure, composition/ and social behavior of such **non-human primate species as gorillas and chimpanzees in an effort to gain clues about our own evolution as a species.**
- **Human genetics** concerns to investigate **how and why the physical traits of contemporary human populations vary** throughout the world. It focuses to examine the genetic materials of an organism such as DNA and RNA.

2. Archaeological Anthropology

- Archaeological anthropology or simply archaeology studies the ways of lives of past peoples by excavating and analyzing the material culture/physical remains (*artefact(objects), features and eco-facts*) they left behind.
- **Artefacts** are *material remains made and used by the past peoples and that can be removed from the site and taken to the laboratory for further analysis*. Tools, ornaments, arrow heads, coins, and fragments of pottery are examples of artifacts.
- **Features** are *like artifacts, are made or modified by past people, but they cannot be readily carried away from the site*. Archaeological features include such things as house foundations, ancient buildings, fireplaces, steles, and postholes.
- **Eco-facts** are *non-artefactual, organic and environmental remains* such as soil, animal bones, and plant remains that were not made or altered by humans; but were used by them. Eco-facts provide archaeologists with important data concerning the environment and how people used natural resources in the past.

- Archaeology has also its own subfields or areas of specialties.
- The most important ones are -***Prehistoric Archaeology and Historical Archaeology***.
- Prehistoric archaeology investigates human prehistory and prehistoric cultures. It focuses on entire period between 6,000 years ago and the time of the first stone tools (the first artifacts), around 2.5 million years ago, is called *prehistory*.
- Historic archaeologists help to reconstruct the cultures of people who used writing and about whom historical documents have been written.
- Historic archaeology takes advantage of the fact that about 6,000 years ago, some human groups invented language and began to write down things that can tell about the past.
- We Ethiopian have very glorious past. Archaeological findings in North, south, east and western part of the country have shown our country belonged to those countries which have old civilization.

3 . Linguistic Anthropology

- Linguistic anthropology **generally focuses on the evolution of languages.**
- It tries to understand languages variation in their structures, units/components/, and grammatical formations. It gives special attention to the study of unwritten languages.
- Language is a key to explore a culture.
- Indeed, linguistic anthropology or anthropological linguistics studies human language as a cultural resource and speaking as a cultural practice in its social and cultural context, across space and time.

- *Language* is basically a system of information transmission and reception. Humans communicate messages by sound (speech), by gesture (body language), and in other visual ways such as writing.
- Analogous to genes that carry and transmit genetic materials to offspring, languages hand down cultural traits from one generation to another.
- In fact, some would argue that language is the most distinctive feature of being human. **Although animals could develop certain behaviors through conditioning that mimic to humans**, they do not have a capacity to pass on their own offspring. This is the boundary between human beings and other animals including higher primates.

- Linguistic anthropology, which **studies contemporary human languages as well as those of the past**, is divided into **four** distinct branches or areas of research:

- ✓ ***Structural or Descriptive Linguistics***,

- ✓ ***Historical Linguistics***,

- ✓ ***Ethno-Linguistics***, and

- ✓ ***Socio-linguistics***.

A. Structural /Descriptive Linguistics: -

- Studies the structure of linguistic patterns.
- It examines sound systems, grammatical systems, and the meanings attached to words in specific languages to understand the structure and set of rules of given language.
- Every culture has a distinctive language with its own logical structure and set of rules for putting words and sounds together for the purpose of communicating.
- In its simplest form, the task of the descriptive linguist is to compile dictionaries and grammar books for previously unwritten languages.

B. Ethno-linguistics (cultural linguistics): -

- Examines the relationship between language and culture.
- In any language, certain cultural aspects that are emphasized (such as types of snow among the Inuit, cows among the pastoral Maasai, or automobiles in U.S. culture) are reflected in the vocabulary.
- Moreover, cultural linguists explore how different linguistic categories can affect how people categorize their experiences, how they think, and how they perceive the world around them.

C. Historical linguistics: -

- Deals with the emergence of language in general and how specific languages have diverged over time.
- It focuses on the comparison and classifications of different languages to differentiate the historical links between them.

D. Socio-linguistics: -

- Investigates linguistic variation within a given language.
- No language is a homogeneous system in which everyone speaks just like everyone else.
- One reason for variation is geography, as in regional dialects and accents.
- Linguistic variation also is expressed in the bilingualism of ethnic groups.

D. Socio-Cultural Anthropology

- It is also often called social anthropology or cultural anthropology. Socio-cultural anthropology is the largest sub-fields of anthropology. It deals with human society and culture.
- **Society is the group of people who have similar ways of life, but culture is a way of life of a group of people.** Society and culture are two sides of the same coin. Socio-cultural anthropology describes, analyzes, interprets, and explains social, cultural and material life of contemporary human societies.
- It studies the social (human relations), symbolic or nonmaterial (religious, language, and any other symbols) and material (all man-made objects) lives of living peoples.
- Socio-cultural anthropologists engage in two aspects of study: ***Ethnography*** (based on field work) and ***Ethnology*** (based on cross-cultural comparison).

A. Ethnography provides a comprehensive account/explanation, interpretation/ of a particular community, society, or culture.

- It describes the features of specific cultures in as much detail as possible including local behavior, beliefs, customs, social life, economic activities, politics, and religion.
- These detailed descriptions (ethnographies) are the result of extensive field studies (usually a year or two, in duration) in which the anthropologist observes, talks to, and lives with the people he or she is studying.
- During ethnographic fieldwork, the anthropologist (ethnographer) gathers data that he or she organizes, describes, analyzes, and interprets to build and present that account, which may be in the form of a book, article, or film.

B. Ethnology is the comparative study of contemporary/ present day, modern day/ cultures and societies, wherever they may be found.

- It examines, interprets, analyzes, and compares the results of ethnography the data gathered in different societies. It uses such data to compare and contrast and to make generalizations about society and culture.
- In other words, **Ethnologists seek to understand both why people today and in the recent past differ in terms of ideas and behavior patterns and what all cultures in the world have in common with one another.**
- Looking beyond the particular to the more general, ethnologists attempt to identify and explain cultural differences and similarities, to test hypotheses/ idea or theory that is not proven, but that leads to further study or discussion/, and to build theory /an idea or a set of ideas that is intended to explain facts or events/ to enhance our understanding of how social and cultural systems work.
- Indeed, the primary objective of ethnology is to uncover general cultural principles, the “rules” that govern human behavior.

❑ **Ethnography:**

- Requires field work to collect data
- Often descriptive
- Group/community specific

❑ **Ethnology:**

- Uses data collected by a series of researchers
- Usually synthetic (copied, unreal, made by combining different substances or not natural)
- Comparative/cross-cultural

❑ Socio-cultural anthropology uses ethnographical and ethnological approaches to answer all sort /kind/ of questions related to culture and human societies.

❑ To properly address emerging questions related to culture and societies, it has been sub-divided into many other specialized fields.

❑ All of them are considered to be the applied areas of anthropology.

Unique (Basic) Features of Anthropology

- Several distinguishing characteristics that identify anthropology from other discipline. Anthropology is unique in its **scope, approach, focus and method of study**.

A. **Scope:** Anthropology has a **broad scope**.

- It is interested in all human beings, whether contemporary or past, "primitive" or "civilized" and that they are interested in many different aspects of humans, including their phenotypic characteristics, family lives, marriages, political systems, economic lives, technology, belief, health care systems, personality types, and languages.
- No place or time is too remote to escape the anthropologist's notice.
- **No dimension of human kind, from genes to art styles, is outside the anthropologist's attention.** Indeed, Anthropology is the broad study of human kind, around the world and throughout time.

B. The second important feature is its approach.

- In its approach anthropology is *holistic, relativistic, and focused* one.
- Holistic in a sense that it looks any phenomena from different vantage points.
- Accordingly, anthropology considers culture, history, language and biology essential to a complete understanding of society.
- Anthropology seeks to understand human beings as whole organisms who adapt to their environments through a complex interaction of biology and culture.
- The concept of relativity is highly appreciated in anthological studies. Anthropology tries to study and explain a certain belief, practice or institution of a group of people in its own context. It does not make value judgment, i.e., declaring that this belief or practice is 'good' or 'bad'.
- **Anthropology's comparative** perspective helps to understand differences and similarities across time and place. Another important perspective is a way of looking at people's ideas.

C. Focus: It considers **insiders' views** as a primary focus of any anthropological inquiry.

- Anthropological studies give attention to how people perceive themselves and understand their world; how a particular group of people explain about their action, or give meaning to their behavior or cultural practices.
- This is what anthropologists **call emic perspective**. It helps to understand the logic and justification behind group behavior and cultural practices.

D. Another important unique feature is its research approach.

- Anthropology is highly dependent on **qualitative research** to understand the **meaning** behind any human activity.
- **Extended fieldwork, participant observation, in-depth and key informant interviews and focus-group discussion** are qualitative research instruments to explore information change and continuities in human societies.

Misconceptions about Anthropology

- ❑ Due to lack of appropriate awareness about the nature, scope and subject matter of the discipline, different misconceptions are held about anthropology:
- One misconception about anthropology is related to the area of its study. It is said that **anthropology is limited to the study of "primitive" societies**. Indeed, most of the works done by anthropologists during early periods focused on isolated, so called "primitive", small scale societies. However, anthropologists nowadays study most advanced and most complex societies as well.
- Another misconception is that anthropologists **only study the rural people and rural areas**. As a matter of fact, most of the studies conducted during the formative years (when it undergone a process of development to be developed as a separate fields of study) of the discipline focused on rural areas. But now, anthropologists are also interested in the study of **urban people and urban areas**. Example ***Urban Anthropology***-which focuses on urban areas and in complex cities.

- It is also wrongly misconceived that Anthropology is the study/analysis of fossil evidences of the proto-humans like that of *Lucy/Dinkeneshe*. It is true that anthropology is interested in the question of the origin of modern human beings. However, this doesn't mean that anthropology is all about the study of human evolution. **It studies both the biological and the cultural aspects of humans and examines the existing human physical and biological variations and cultural diversity.**
- It is also misconceived that the purpose of anthropology is to study in order to keep and preserve communities far from development and obsolete(outdated) cultural practices in museums. Rather, anthropologists' duties are to support those communities' capacity to empower themselves in development processes. They assist peoples' initiatives instead of imposed policies and ideas coming from outside and play active roles in bringing about positive change and development in their own lives.

The Relationship between Anthropology and Other Disciplines

- Anthropology is similar with other social sciences such as sociology, psychology, political sciences, economics, history, etc.
- Anthropology greatly overlaps with these disciplines that study human society.
- However, anthropology differs from other social sciences and the humanities by its ***broad scope, unique approach, perspective, unit of analysis*** and ***methods used***.
- In its **scope**, anthropology studies humankind in its entirety.
- In its **approach**, anthropology studies and analyzes human ways of *life holistically, comparatively* and in a *relativistic manner*.

- In its **perspective**, according to Richard Wilk, anthropology approaches and locates **dimensions of people's individual and communal lived experiences, their thoughts and their feelings in terms of how these dimensions are interconnected and interrelated to one another**, yet not necessarily constrained or very orderly, whole. The perspective is also fundamentally ***empirical, naturalistic*** and ***ideographic*** [particularizing] than ***nomothetic*** [universalizing] one.
- In its **method of research**, it is unique in that it undertakes ***extended fieldwork among the studied community and develops intimate knowledge of the life and social worlds of its study group/society*** through employing those ethnographic data collection techniques such as participant observation, Key informant interview and focus group discussions.

The Contributions of anthropology

- The philosophical underpinning is that since we are human beings, we have to know our civilization. Anthropology has established for itself the task of examining all aspects of humanity for all periods of time and for all parts of the globe.
- **By studying anthropology, we get the following benefits, among others:**
- First, the anthropological perspective, with its **emphasis on the comparative study of cultures, should lead us to the conclusion that our culture is just one way of life among many found in the world** and that it represents one way (among many possible ways) to adapt to a particular set of environmental conditions. **Through the process of contrasting and comparing, we gain a fuller understanding of other cultures and our own.**

- Anthropology also helps us better understand ourselves or our own ways of life. As a mirror of human life, by studying others, we can better understand ourselves. Hence, it gives opportunity to understand and to be critical about the ways of lives of our own community.
- Anthropology gives us an insight into different ways and modes of life of human society (social and cultural diversity), which helps to understand the logic and justification behind group behavior and cultural practices. Knowledge about the rest of the world is particularly important today because the world has become increasingly interconnected. So, today it is important that we not only know something about other peoples of the world, but also grasp how our everyday decisions are influencing them in a multitude of ways and how others' decisions are also influencing ours.

- Through its distinctive (distinguishing, individual) methodology of long-term, intensive, participant-observation research, cultural anthropology offers a unique perspective on how local cultural groups are engaging with the process of globalization.
- Because of its *relativistic approach*, anthropology helps us to be more sensitive to and appreciative of cultural diversity and variability.
- It helps us to avoid some of the misunderstandings that commonly arise when individuals of different cultural traditions come into contact.
- Anthropology helps us fight against prejudice (bias) and discriminations. It helps us fight against **ethnocentrism**; the belief that one's own culture and one's own way of life is superior to others cultural, social and material life. This arises from ignorance about other ethnic groups and their ways of lives.

- Anthropology is also used as a tool for development. Paying attention to local conditions, is crucial to solve community problems.
- The application of anthropological knowledge and research results have become important element to ensure people's rights in development and able to sustain projects' life.
- Anthropologists are better equipped with the knowledge, skills and methods of identifying the needs and interests of local people for the betterment and change of their lived experiences. It recognizes the advantages of consulting local people to design a culturally appropriate and socially sensitive change, and protect local people from harmful policies and projects that threaten them.
- In general, anthropology is able to suggest sound solutions to all things human.